



MIXING DRUMS CHEAT SHEET



4 STEPS TO MIXING DRUMS: THE BASK TECHNIQUE

1. Balance

- Completely turn down all of the individual drum faders.
- Then, bring the level of each individual drum up in order of importance.
 - Usually this is snare, kick, overheads, and so on.
- Balance the volumes of each until they sound good with the mix.

2. Aux

- Start with mixing the drum buss first.
- Listen to the drums for issues.
 - Do you hear any overall muddiness? Any harshness?
 - Use an EQ to fix this.

- Try using parallel compression to make the drums more lively and punchy.
 - Make sure the compressor you use has a mix knob so that you can use parallel compression without having to create a send.

3. Snare

- Where does the snare need to go tonally?
 - First, use an EQ to cut any unnecessary low end.
 - Then make small cuts where other instruments need to shine. Check out [this video on range allocation](#) for more info.
 - Add any boosts you think are necessary for the tone.
 - Make sure to avoid boosting where other major instruments have been boosted.
 - Boost around 100-200Hz for body
 - Boost somewhere in the upper mids (around 5-10kHz) for crack
 - Add saturation if you need to bring out any extra warmth or brightness.
- Add compression.
 - You can be pretty aggressive with this.
 - Try using 10dB of gain reduction with a high ratio for an aggressive sound.
 - For the attack time, think: do I want the snare to sound thicker (fast attack) or punchier (slow attack)?
 - Start with...
 - 4:1 ratio
 - 20ms attack time
 - 5-10dB of gain reduction
 - More gain reduction in genres like rock, metal and hardcore
 - Auto-release
 - Manual makeup gain
- Add reverb
 - If you are using one mix-wide room reverb, just send the snare to that.

4. Kick

- Compare the kick to the bass.
 - Where is the bass cut or boosted? [Make sure to do the opposite.](#)
 - When you look at a spectrum analyzer, where's the majority of the basses energy? Make sure to add a cut there in the kick.
- Where does the kick need to go tonally?
 - First, use an EQ to clean up the sub-bass (<~30Hz)
 - Then make small cuts where other instruments need to shine. Check out [this video on range allocation](#) for more info.
 - Add any boosts you think are necessary for the tone.
 - Make sure to avoid boosting where other major instruments have been boosted.
 - Add saturation if you need to bring out any extra warmth or brightness.

- Add compression
 - You can be pretty aggressive with this.
 - Try using 10dB of gain reduction with a high ratio for an aggressive sound.
 - For the attack time, think: do I want the kick to sound thicker (fast attack) or punchier (slow attack)?
 - Start with...
 - 4:1 ratio
 - 20ms attack time
 - 5-10dB of gain reduction
 - More gain reduction in genres like rock, metal and hardcore
 - Auto-release
 - Manual makeup gain

Once you've finished the BASK technique, **add any final touches necessary**. Check out your overheads, hi-hat, and toms. Do they need any EQ/compression/reverb/etc.?

Make sure you always have an intention when you're mixing. Never make any tweaks "just because." Do this, and the BASK technique will work for your drums every time!